KCC CODE CLUB · GAME MAKERS

Volunteer Briefing

Read before week one

Read this once before week one. It's the whole job in about ten minutes.

What you're signing up for

Eight Saturdays (or whichever day), an hour each plus about 30 minutes of setup, and maybe half an hour of prep the night before. Then the showcase, an evening with the families, after the last class. One volunteer per five students and never fewer than two, so a class of fifteen needs three of you in the room — see the program overview for the full table and the spares policy.

You do not need to be a programmer. You need to be able to stay calm, ask good questions, and resist the urge to fix things yourself. If you can do those three, you can run this room.

The two roles

The lead

Runs the front of the room: the live demo, briefing the activity, keeping time. Prepares by reading the lesson plan and building that week's project checkpoint themselves beforehand — you want to hit the bugs before the children do.

The floaters

Never sit down. Circulate constantly during activity and project time, spotting the child who is stuck and hasn't said so. This is the harder and more important job, and every volunteer who isn't leading is doing it.

With three or more floaters, give each one a zone — a couple of tables each — rather than letting everyone wander the whole room. Unzoned floaters cluster around whoever is loudest and the quiet child in the corner still gets missed, which is the exact failure the extra staffing was supposed to fix.

Rotate the lead between weeks so more than one person can run a session. Don't swap mid-session.

The one rule of helping

Never take the mouse.

It is enormously tempting. A child is stuck, you can see the problem instantly, and it would take you four seconds. Do not do it. You will have solved the bug and taught nothing, and they will call you over again in ninety seconds.

Instead, put your hands behind your back and ask:

1. *"What did you expect it to do?"*
2. *"What did it actually do?"*
3. *"Show me the part where you think it goes wrong."*

Most children solve their own bug somewhere in question two. That moment — the one where they fix it themselves and look up — is the entire product. Don't steal it.

If they're genuinely stuck after that, point at the screen and describe what you see. "I notice your `if` block is outside the loop." Let them make the change.

Being deliberately wrong is part of the job

Every lesson plan has a **deliberate mistake** in the live demo. Do it. Make the error, run it, look puzzled, say "huh, that's not what I expected", and work through it out loud.

Children arrive believing that adults who are good at computers never get errors, and that getting an error means you're bad at it. Watching you be confused and calm, repeatedly, over eight weeks, is more valuable than any concept in the curriculum.

Never say "this is easy". If it were easy they'd have done it.

Practical ground rules

- **Two adults in the room at all times, minimum.** If you drop below two on the day and there's no backup available, cancel the session. Don't run it solo.
- **Never be alone with a child.** If a one-to-one conversation is needed, have it in the room where the other volunteer can see you.
- **Stay in the room.** Toilet breaks in pairs or with a parent, per the club's policy.
- **No photos on personal phones.** Use the club device, and check the photo permission list first — some children are marked no-photos and you need to know which.
- **No private contact with students.** Everything goes through parents. No adding students on social media, no direct messaging, including on Scratch.
- **Follow the club's child protection policy.** Read it. If you have a concern about a child's welfare, report it to [NAMED PERSON] the same day. Don't investigate it yourself and don't sit on it.
- **Check the health notes** on the consent forms before week one, especially allergies if there's food at the showcase.

Managing the room

Names. Learn all of them by week two. Name stickers in week one; use them constantly.

The talker. Every group has a child who narrates everything. Give them a job — make them a "helper" who assists their neighbour. It works startlingly well.

The one who's finished in five minutes. Bonus challenges, then ask them to help someone. Never let them sit idle; that's when a room turns.

The one who's silently stuck. The hardest to spot and the most important. Look for the child whose screen hasn't changed in five minutes and who isn't asking. Go to them. Don't announce it.

The one who's upset. Usually because they lost work or they think they're the worst in the room. Sit down next to them, fix the immediate thing, and tell them truthfully that everyone in the room has had the same bug.

Volume. A coding club should be a bit loud. Children talking about their games is the sound of it working. Only intervene when it's stopping people thinking.

Timing, honestly

You will run over. Everyone does, and an hour has very little slack. When you do, cut in this order:

1. The class activity — stop it at the quarter-hour, wherever they've got to
2. The optional steps of the project build — push them into homework

Never cut the core of the project build, Show & Tell, or saving at the end. There's no break to cut: at an hour, the class runs straight through.

The end-of-session ritual

The last five minutes matter more than they look:

1. Everyone saves. **Walk the room and check the screens.** Don't take their word for it.
2. Nobody leaves with a broken game. If someone's project is in pieces, fix it *with* them or roll them back to the skeleton.
3. Brief the homework in one sentence.
4. Say what's happening next week.

If you can't make a session

Tell the lead as early as you can and help find the backup. The lesson plans are written so that someone else can pick one up and run it cold — that's deliberate, and it's why they're as detailed as they are.

Who to ask

Thing	Person
Anything about a child's welfare	[NAMED PERSON], same day
Venue, keys, access	[NAME]
Scratch accounts, passwords	[NAME]
Curriculum, lesson plans	[NAME]
A parent complaint or concern	[NAME] — don't handle it alone